

A NEW WAY Multidisciplinary artist Nikhil Chopra

ART ▼

A NEW ECOSYSTEM

NIKHIL CHOPRA, CURATOR OF THE SIXTH EDITION OF THE KOCHI-MUZIRIS BIENNALE, WANTS TO MAKE IT A LIVING EXCHANGE OF ARTISTIC PRACTICES

"What we're really thinking about is how to collapse the distance between studio and exhibition, rehearsal and performance, process and object," says multidisciplinary artist Nikhil Chopra, curator of the sixth edition of the Kochi-Muziris Biennale. Titled *For the Time Being*, the edition invites artists to engage with Kochi and create site-specific work. Alongside static works like paintings, sculptures and installations, there will be sound, movement and choreography, creating a dynamic relationship between audiences and artworks. "No matter which day an audience visits, there will always be a live element to encounter, allowing for a constantly shifting, interactive experience," elaborates Chopra, who put up a 52-hour immersive live performance for the Biennale's 2014 edition. The Biennale is co-curated by HH Art Spaces, a Goa-based artist-led organisation co-founded by Chopra.

Kochi's location along key trade routes historically connecting Europe and Asia put it in the unique position of becoming a melting pot of ideas, languages and cultures. The city will be fertile ground for the Biennale's invited artists to create works *in situ*. "It becomes particularly interesting to bring in contemporary art as a way to mirror and reflect on the histories that have shaped this internationalism, especially within the context of contemporary practice. It allows us to think openly from a position of hospitality," says Chopra.

The exhibition in Kochi marks the city's history as a trade hub, as a melting pot of cultures, ideas and arts

As with past editions, the historic Aspinwall House will be at the heart of the Biennale. Built in 1867, it is one in a chain of warehouses that line Kochi port where goods—spices, minerals, timber and even labour—were collected, stored and shipped out to Europe and America. "These spaces are thick with history, holding the ghosts of what came before. Aspinwall allows us to create dialogues that transcend time, place and geography, addressing not only current systems of trade and commerce but also how their legacies have reshaped Kochi," says Chopra. "By de-emphasising the finished object and prioritising process, we're inviting audiences to witness the making of a Biennale in real-time," adds Chopra. ■

—Prachi Joshi

The Biennale will run from Dec. 12, 2025 to Mar. 31, 2026